

Style guide

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This write-up introduces Style guides and explains their role in consistent technical writing.

Introduction

Style guides serve as the single source of truth for writers, User Experience (UX) designers, and developers. Organizations define their own style guides or use a standard reference such as the Microsoft style guide. They bring consistency and professionalism to documents, UX designs, and code. Readers know what to expect and where to find specific information in documents created using a style guide.

What are style guides?

A style guide contains guidelines on various aspects of writing and UX designs, such as:

1. Tone and voice
2. Grammar and language rules
3. Terminology
4. Formatting standards
5. Versioning standards

Contributors can refer to their organization's style guide while writing and creating UX designs.

Key benefits of style guides

1. Following a style guide brings consistency to documents and UX designs created by one or more contributors within the organization. Even when a single author writes a document, inconsistencies can occur. When multiple authors write different sections of a document or multiple documents for an organization, adhering to the style guide brings consistency to their output.
2. A style guide helps in resolving conflicts. There are multiple correct ways to write a sentence. When deciding between two variants, the style guide is an authoritative reference.

Essential elements of style guides

A style guide contains guidelines for the following:

1. Voice and tone

For example:

- a. Use the active voice in sentences.
Passive voice can be used if absolutely required.
- b. Use an empathetic tone.
Technical documents are not meant to be humorous, persuasive, or commanding.

This makes the document simple and direct.

2. Grammar and language

A style guide specifies the grammar and language rules to use. For example:

- a. Writing should be free of spelling, grammar, punctuation, and typographical errors.
- b. How to frame sentences: Should they be in U.S. or U.K. English?
- c. How to write date and time. Dates are specified using
 - i. mm/dd/yyyy in U.S. English.
 - ii. dd/mm/yyyy in U.K. English.
- d. How to use punctuation, such as the Oxford comma, for U.K. English.
- e. How to write currency symbols.
- f. Do not use Latin phrases such as e.g. or i.e. Instead, use for example, or that is.

Error-free grammar and appropriate language make documents easy to read.

3. Terminology

A style guide provides a glossary of industry-specific terminology. Writers can then use these terms in documents and include a glossary.

A glossary makes the document compact and less overwhelming.

4. Bias-free writing

A style guide specifies what biases technical writing should be free from. For example, technical writing should be free of biases related to:

- a. Gender
- b. Color
- c. Race
- d. Ethnicity
- e. Religion
- f. Sexual orientation

These rules ensure the document is respectful and inclusive.

5. Typographical conventions

A style guide specifies how text should look on the page:

- a. Capitalization rules
- b. Emphasis rules
- c. Any other special formatting

These rules ensure the document looks professional and visually appealing.

6. Formatting standards

For example, the font-related details below are specified by a style guide:

	Style	Font	Font size	Color
Title	Heading 1	Sans-serif	18 pt	Black
Section	Heading 2	Sans-serif	14 pt	Black
Sub-section	Heading 3	Sans-serif	12 pt	Black
Text	Normal text	Sans-serif	11 pt	Black

These rules make the document consistent and professional.

7. Logo

A style guide specifies the logo to be used in documents and its placement in documents.

These rules ensure branding and professionalism in documents.

8. Procedure writing

A style guide should specify:

- The starting sentence.
- The length of sentences.
- If images should be included in the procedure.

These rules ensure consistency in procedure documentation.

9. Versioning standards

A style guide specifies how to specify version information in documents. For example:

- The cover page for documents should specify a **Version: XX**.
- Revision history and changes in each revision should be included in the document.

Conclusion

By following a style guide, you can create clear, consistent, and professional documents and UX designs for your organization. This results in better branding and credibility for your business.